



BIOLOGICS FOR PSORIASIS

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Biologic medications for psoriasis are created from living cells in a lab or through a biological pathway, giving their name. Biologic agents target specific molecules within the immune system, including inflammatory messengers called cytokines. They have made incremental progress within the past two decades in both safety and efficacy for treatment and have also shed light on the autoimmune aspect of psoriasis, allowing for a more targeted approach to therapy.

Depending on the specific biologic, these agents interfere with inflammatory markers such as, TNF- α , IL-17, or IL-23, minimizing the inflammatory component of psoriasis and preventing the immune attack on the skin and joints, allowing for the skin to return to its healthy baseline state. Currently, there are twelve FDA approved biologic medications for psoriasis, targeting different immunologic pathways within psoriasis pathophysiology cascade. They are approved for treating both psoriasis and psoriatic arthritis. Biologics may be administered by intravenous (IV) infusion in a clinic setting, or at home using an auto-injection given to the patient. Possible side effects for biologic agents include upper respiratory tract infection, skin reaction at site of injection, flu-like symptoms, urinary tract infection, and headache. Biologics cause immunosuppression, increasing the risk of developing infection. This risk is higher in patients with co-morbid conditions such as diabetes, smokers, or who have a history of infections.

Main factors that a clinician must consider when choosing a biologic treatment include safety, such as short-term tolerability and long-term risk issues, efficacy, co-morbid conditions, cost, and convenience of the treatment.

References:

Brownstone, N. D., Hong, J., Mosca, M., Haderler, E., Liao, W., Bhutani, T., & Koo, J. (2021). Biologic Treatments of Psoriasis: An Update for the Clinician. *Biologics : targets & therapy*, 15, 39–51. <https://doi.org/10.2147/BTT.S252578>

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